

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Aegithalidae

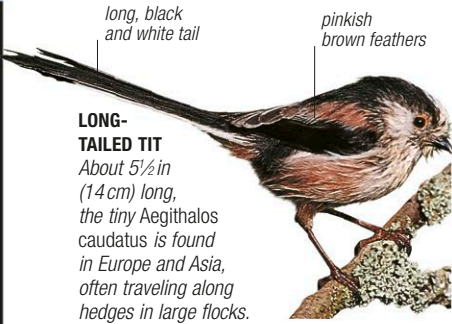
Bushtits

Length 4¼–5½ in (11–14 cm)

Species 13



In a separate family from the true tits, this group includes long-tailed tits as well as the North American bush tit. They have short, conical bills and may be more closely related to Old World warblers. They are found in North and Central America, Europe, and Asia. A Himalayan subspecies of the Eurasian long-tailed tit occurs up to 11,200 ft (3,400 m), but descends lower in winter. Groups of long-tailed tits roost together, huddled along a branch. Breeding pairs sometimes have a “helper,” a bird that does not mate but helps feed the young. The domed nest is lined with feathers and can take up to 20 days to build. Clutch sizes range from 4 to 12.



LONG-TAILED TIT
About 5½ in (14 cm) long, the tiny Aegithalos caudatus is found in Europe and Asia, often traveling along hedges in large flocks.

Family Remizidae

Penduline tits

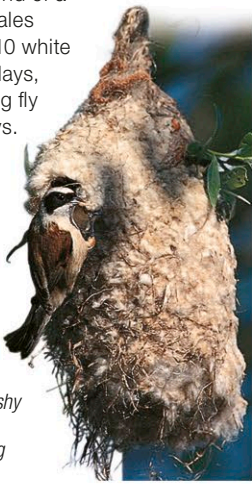
Length 3¼–5½ in (8–14 cm)

Species 11



These birds, found in North America, Europe, Asia, and Africa, are even more acrobatic than true tits (see p.355), and can climb along the underside of branches. They pick invertebrates off branches and foliage, and also eat seeds and fruit. Small birds with fine, pointed bills, penduline tits forage in groups and nest colonially. Their nest is an unusual pouchlike structure, with a spoutlike entrance tunnel, woven from grass and roots, and hung at the end of a branch. Females incubate 5–10 white eggs for 12 days, and the young fly in 16–18 days.

EURASIAN PENDULINE TIT
Remiz pendulinus, 4¼ in (11 cm) long, uses the down from bulrushes that grow in its marshy habitat to build its nest. Its song is unobtrusive.



Family Cisticolidae

Cisticolas and allies

Length 10–15 cm (4–6 in)

Species 158



This family of birds is dominated by 3 large genera: the mostly African Cisticola and Apalis, and the Afro-Asian Prinia. These birds lack bright colors, but have distinctive calls and were previously classified with Old World warblers—though they are still considered closely related to them. Cisticolas habitually flick and fan their tails and are found in a



ZITTING CISTICOLA
Found in Europe, Africa, Asia, and Australia, Cisticola juncidis is only 4 in (10 cm) long, but is disproportionately active and noisy. It has a bouncy, circular song-flight: it beats its wings rapidly to rise, utters a “tzet” call, then drops before rising again. Its fan-shaped tail has black and white markings on the underside.

variety of open habitats—including grasslands and wetlands. Apalis and Prinia are longer-tailed, most Apalis are found in woodland and Prinia in scrub. Their nests are grassy cups, sometimes supported by large leaves. This behavior is taken to a remarkable extent in tailorbirds from Southeast Asia. They are well known for building their nests within a cradle made by sewing the edges of a leaf together with fibers.

TAWNY-FLANKED PRINIA
Found in Asia and southern and eastern Africa, Prinia subflava has a monotonous “chip, chip” song and a harsh, scolding “sbeee” call. A restless, sprightly bird, it is 4¾ in (12 cm) long, and forages in pairs or small flocks in scrub or vegetation.



Family Panuridae

Bearded reedling

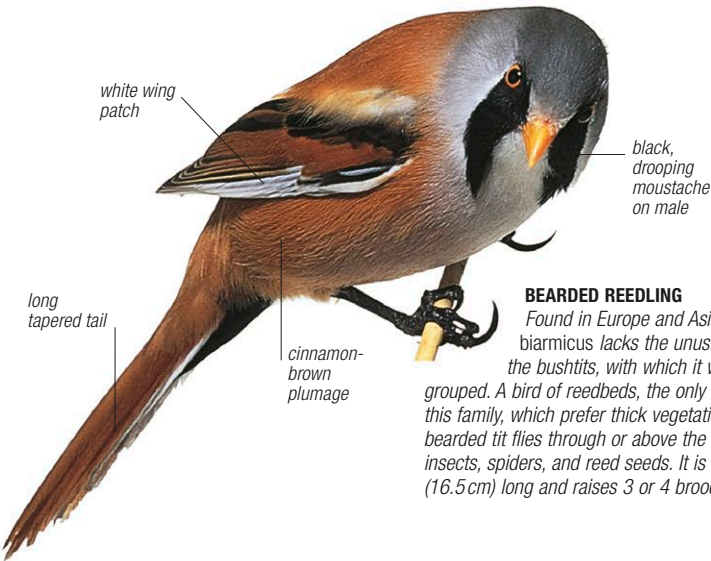
Length 6½ in (16 cm)

Species 1



Some birds are opportunistic and flexible while others are restricted to narrowly defined habitats; this bird is confined to standing beds of tall reeds in fresh water. It requires areas of wet reedbed, nesting in rigid stems

above water for protection, but also drier places with dead leaf litter in which it can find accumulated insects and seeds. Reedbeds are often far apart, but in “good” years, when reedling populations reach a maximum, birds will “erupt” from them and disperse over wide areas in search of new sites; sometimes, they will then appear in less pure stands of fen and marsh vegetation. The birds can be detected by loud, ringing calls, but may be elusive, their progress indicated only by rustling stems.



BEARDED REEDLING
Found in Europe and Asia, Panurus biarmicus lacks the unusual bill of the bushtits, with which it was previously grouped. A bird of reedbeds, the only species in this family, which prefer thick vegetation, the bearded tit flies through or above the reeds, eating insects, spiders, and reed seeds. It is 6½ in (16.5 cm) long and raises 3 or 4 broods a year.

Family Bernieridae

Malagasy warblers

Length 7 in (15 cm)

Species 11



Most of these warblers live in the dwindling forests of eastern Madagascar; some have only recently been discovered and described. They were previously split among other bird families, such as bulbuls, babblers, and Old World warblers, but are now grouped together in a somewhat mixed group. They are all insect-eaters, and inconspicuous birds of dense or low growth. Four or five species can sometimes be seen feeding together.



LONG-BILLED BERNIERIA
A bird of moist, lowland forests in Madagascar, resembling a small, green bulbul with a long bill, this bird often joins mixed flocks when feeding.

Family Phylloscopidae

Leaf warblers and allies

Length 4–7 in (9–15 cm)

Species 77



These insectivorous, woodland birds include familiar species in Europe and Asia, and others that breed in remote areas of Asia but sometimes appear as rare waifs in the west. Greenish or olive, paler beneath, they have varied head stripes and wing bars, different leg colors, or minute structural differences, and some are best identified by their songs and calls.

WILLOW WARBLER
A summer visitor to northern Europe and an inhabitant of Africa during winter, Phylloscopus trochilus has no particular association with willows. It can best be separated from the very similar chiffchaff, Phylloscopus collybita, by its melancholic song.

